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MAC 101: Introduction to Mass Communication - Media, Audiences and Ethics

How messages reach millions, and who decides what counts as news

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Social Sciences
Mass Communication | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Mass communication is studied as a system of institutions, technologies, audiences and effects. This pack covers the communication process, media functions and theories, news values, and the ethical and legal issues Nigerian journalists face.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the communication process and the difference between interpersonal and mass communication.
- Describe the functions of the mass media and evaluate normative theories of the press.
- Apply news values to explain why one story leads and another is buried.
- Identify core ethical and legal issues in Nigerian media practice.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The communication process

Every communication event can be broken into components, and each component can fail.

- Sender, encoding, message, channel, noise, receiver, decoding, feedback.
- Interpersonal communication is direct and reciprocal; mass communication is mediated, public and one-to-many.
- Noise can be physical, semantic, psychological or channel-related.
- Feedback in mass communication is delayed and indirect, for example ratings or comments.
- Digital media blur the line by allowing audience participation at scale.

- A model is a simplification; use it to analyse, not to pretend reality is tidy.

Functions and theories of the press

Media do more than inform, and different societies expect different things from them.

- Functions: surveillance, interpretation, transmission of culture, socialisation, entertainment and mobilisation.
- Authoritarian theory: media serve the state.
- Libertarian theory: media should be free and open.
- Social responsibility theory: freedom carries obligations to accuracy and public interest.
- Soviet-communist and development media theories emphasise collective goals.
- Gatekeeping, agenda-setting and framing explain how media shape what audiences think about.

> **Agenda-setting versus telling you what to think**
> Media may not dictate your opinion, but they influence which issues you consider important. That distinction is examinable and worth stating precisely.

News values, ethics and law

News is a construction governed by professional routines and constraints.

- News values: timeliness, proximity, prominence, consequence, conflict, novelty and human interest.
- Ethics: accuracy, fairness, balance, privacy, avoiding plagiarism and correcting errors promptly.
- Law: defamation, contempt of court, copyright, and rules on official secrets.
- Free expression is constitutionally protected but limited by law and public interest.
- Self-regulation through codes of conduct matters where enforcement is weak.
- Digital verification, source protection and misinformation are now core professional skills.

The models that explain the field

Mass communication studies how messages reach large, dispersed audiences through media institutions. The classic transmission model - source, encoding, message, channel, noise, decoding, receiver, feedback - is useful for identifying where communication fails, but it treats meaning as something sent rather than negotiated.

The alternative is the cultural or ritual model, which treats communication as the construction of shared meaning. A broadcast does not simply deliver information; it produces a way of seeing. Understanding both models lets you analyse a news report as simultaneously a transmission of facts and a ritual reaffirming what a society treats as important.

Gatekeeping explains why some events become news and others do not. Editors, producers and platforms select, and their selection follows news values: proximity, prominence, consequence, novelty, conflict, human interest. These values are not natural; they are conventions that can be studied and criticised.

Media effects and audience agency

Early models assumed powerful, direct effects - the hypodermic needle. Later research found limited effects, with audiences filtering messages through existing beliefs and group affiliations. The two-step flow model proposed that opinion leaders mediate media influence; cultivation theory argued that repeated exposure shapes perceptions of reality; agenda-setting argued that media tell us what to think about, not what to think.

The current consensus is neither omnipotence nor harmlessness. Effects depend on the message, the audience, the context and the repetition. Uses and gratifications theory reframes the question by asking what audiences do with media rather than what media do to audiences.

Digital platforms complicate all of this. Algorithms select content at scale, engagement metrics reward emotional content, and misinformation spreads because it is shareable rather than because it is persuasive. Media literacy - verifying sources, checking claims, understanding platform incentives - has become a basic civic skill.

> **Follow the incentive**
> Ask who is paid, and for what. Advertising-funded media optimise attention; subscription media optimise retention; public media optimise legitimacy. The business model explains more than the editorial statement.

The Nigerian media landscape

Nigerian media includes a large and vibrant press, dozens of television stations, hundreds of radio stations (the most trusted medium in much of the country), a dominant film industry, and an enormous social media sector. Radio's reach in local languages makes it the most important medium for rural information.

Press freedom is contested. Reporting on corruption, security and politics carries risk, and journalists face legal pressure, harassment and worse. Ownership matters: media owned by political or business interests report within limits that are rarely stated.

The regulatory environment includes the National Broadcasting Commission, which licenses stations and enforces a broadcasting code, and various press bodies. Understanding the difference between statutory regulation, self-regulation and platform governance is examinable.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Analysing a news story

Take one front-page story and analyse it as a communication act.

1. Identify the source: who is quoted, who is not, and who benefits from the framing.
2. Identify the news values that made it a story.
3. Note what is in the lead paragraph and what is buried.
4. Identify the assumed reader: what does the story expect you to already know or feel?
5. Look for loaded vocabulary that carries evaluation.
6. State what alternative framing would have been possible.

> **What to carry forward**
> Framing is visible in what is quoted, what is placed first, and which words carry evaluation.

2. Evaluating a viral claim

A screenshot circulates claiming a policy change. Assess it in five minutes.

1. Identify the original source and whether it exists.
2. Check the date - old content recirculates.
3. Search for the same claim from an independent outlet.
4. Check whether the image is cropped or edited.
5. Assess the incentive of whoever first shared it.
6. Report your confidence level rather than a verdict.

> **What to carry forward**
> Source, date, corroboration, editing, incentive. Five checks, five minutes.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Compare the transmission and cultural models of communication.

15 marks

1. Transmission: linear transfer, noise, feedback, focus on accuracy.
2. Cultural: meaning negotiated, ritual, shared frames.
3. Apply both to one broadcast.
4. Explain what each model cannot explain.

Q2. Discuss the claim that audiences are active rather than passive.

20 marks

1. Set out the direct-effects position.
2. Present evidence for limited effects and selectivity.
3. Use uses and gratifications theory.
4. Acknowledge algorithmic influence and platform power.
5. Conclude that activity is constrained, not free.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Choosing pure passivity or pure agency. The marks are in the constraint.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Gatekeeping. The selection process deciding which events become news.

News values. Criteria such as proximity, prominence and conflict that shape selection.

Agenda-setting. The media's influence over which issues audiences consider important.

Cultivation. The shaping of perceptions through repeated exposure to media content.

Two-step flow. Influence passing from media to opinion leaders and then to others.

Uses and gratifications. A theory explaining media use by the needs audiences seek to satisfy.

Framing. Selecting and emphasising aspects of an issue to promote an interpretation.

Encoding and decoding. Producing meaning in a message and interpreting it, which may diverge.

Media literacy. The ability to access, analyse, evaluate and produce media messages.

Public sphere. The space where citizens debate matters of common concern.

Self-regulation. Media governing itself through codes and councils rather than statute.

Concentration of ownership. Few owners controlling many outlets, reducing diversity of voice.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Models

Frameworks.

- Draw the transmission model.
- Explain its limits.
- Re-read one story through the cultural model.

Week 2 - Selection

Gatekeeping.

- List news values found in five stories.
- Identify one buried fact.
- Interview someone about what they think is missing.

Week 3 - Effects

Audiences.

- Summarise three effects theories.
- Apply uses and gratifications to your own media use.
- Trace one viral claim.

Week 4 - Context

Nigeria.

- Map ownership of three outlets.
- Explain the regulatory framework.
- Write a 15-mark answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any introduction to mass communication covering models, effects and news values.
- A media and society text with African case studies.
- A guide to verifying claims and sources for journalism students.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name the components of the communication process.

Answer: Sender, encoding, message, channel, noise, receiver, decoding and feedback.

2. What does agenda-setting theory argue?

Answer: That media influence the salience of issues, shaping what audiences regard as important rather than directly telling them what to think.

3. List four news values.

Answer: Timeliness, proximity, prominence and conflict. Consequence, novelty and human interest are also standard.

4. Distinguish defamation from contempt of court.

Answer: Defamation is a false statement that damages reputation; contempt is conduct that interferes with the administration of justice, such as prejudicial reporting of a pending case.

5. Why is social responsibility theory relevant in Nigeria?

Answer: The Constitution guarantees press freedom, but media are expected to serve the public interest, be accurate and avoid inciting harm.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Draw and label the communication process model.
- [ ] List five functions of the mass media with Nigerian examples.
- [ ] Compare libertarian and social responsibility theory in a table.
- [ ] Apply news values to three front-page stories.
- [ ] List six ethical duties of a journalist.
- [ ] Summarise one defamation case and its lesson for reporters.
- [ ] Write a 250-word analysis of a news story's framing.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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